

30 Minutes Expert Flash Forward!

The BIOS is a tiny chip on your motherboard, which provides the basic instructions for operating your hardware. Updating your BIOS can eliminate nagging problems due to bugs and add features that give your motherboard a new lease of life.

The process of flashing involves rewriting the EEPROM of your BIOS chip with newer instructions and patches. This will take a maximum of 1 minute or even less. The process explained here is applicable to the more popular Award BIOS. Before you begin, make sure you have a Windows 9x bootable floppy disk handy.

STEP 1 Identify your motherboard and the current BIOS version. Press the [Pause] key while your system boots up and note down the signature of your BIOS. The name of the BIOS



Check for the BIOS ID and the name of the manufacturer on the Bootup screen

manufacturer shows up at the top left corner of the screen while your system does a memory check. The BIOS ID string is the long string displayed at the bottom left corner of the screen. In the third part of the string, the sixth and seventh characters denote the motherboard manufacturer. For example, in the ID 'i815-w83627-6a69rd4dc-00', 'd4' in the third part of the string denotes the

motherboard manufacturer, in this case, DFI (Diamond Flower).

If your motherboard uses an Award BIOS, you can check for the manufacturer at www.abios.com/award.html. If it uses an AMI (American Megatrends) BIOS, check www.abios.com/ami.html.

STEP 2 Depending on the type of your BIOS (Award, Phoenix, AMI, etc), download the latest flash utility and the necessary update file from your motherboard manufacturer's Web site to a floppy disk. Unzip the files. There should be three files in all: a .exe file, a .bin file (the BIOS update) and a .txt file. Copy the .exe and .bin files to the bootable floppy disk.

STEP 3 Boot your PC in the DOS mode using your bootable floppy. See to it that no memory management programs or emulators such as emm386.exe are running, as this might interrupt the update process.

STEP 4 To run the flash utility type the executable filename with the parameter as follows:

A:\> [executable file] [bin file]

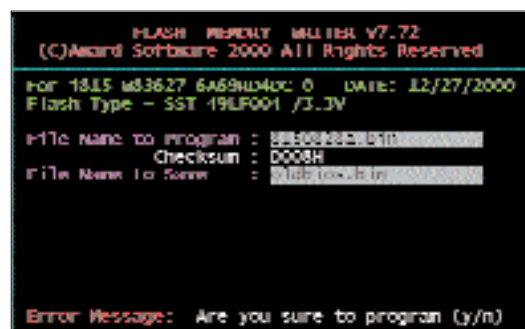
You can type [executable file] / ? to seek help on using the file.

STEP 5 Most flash updating utilities have an option to backup your old BIOS settings. Make sure that you backup the current BIOS to a file by using the same utility.

STEP 6 Check the path of the .bin file and press [Enter] to proceed. You'll be asked for a confirmation. Press [Y] to continue. The software will automatically update your BIOS. During this update period there should be no power surges or



Flashing your BIOS can be fatal for your motherboard, if there is a power failure or surge during the flashing process. If your system is working fine and you don't find any problems with your motherboard, DO NOT upgrade your BIOS. If you do decide to upgrade your BIOS, make sure to get some assistance from an engineer or a person who is well versed in computer hardware.



The flash utility screen showing the BIOS update process

electrical disturbances, else your BIOS can get corrupted and you would have to replace it (if the BIOS is socketed) or buy a new motherboard (if it's hardwired).

STEP 7 Now exit the flash updating utility, reboot the PC and enter the BIOS settings by pressing [Del] while your system boots. Load the BIOS defaults by pressing [F6] or [F7], as required. Now when you reboot your PC, your BIOS ID at the bottom left corner of the screen should show the new date (the date on which you flashed your BIOS).

You're done. Now your PC will run smooth and steady with the newer instructions written into your BIOS. Hardware compatibility issues and bugs, if any, will also get resolved when you flash the BIOS. ■

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